

The Liturgy

Sunday Mass Saturday: 6.00 pm (Vigil Mass) Sunday: 9.30 am 12.00 noon	<u>Weekday Mass Times</u> Monday: 7.00 pm Tuesday: 9.30 am Wednesday: 9.30 am Thursday: 9.30 am Friday: 7.00 pm Saturday: 12 noon
Confession Monday: 7.30 pm – 8.00 pm Friday: 6.30 pm – 7.00 pm Saturday: 12.30 pm – 1.00 pm & 5.30 pm – 6:00 pm Eucharistic Adoration Monday: 7.30 pm – 8.00 pm	Baptisms 1 st & 3 rd Sunday of the Month at 1.30pm Please contact the Parish Office to book <i>(One month's notice required)</i> Marriages At least 6 months' notice required prior to date of Marriage. Please contact Fr Sheehan

PARISH OFFERTORY COLLECTION

(Total includes Basket Collections, Standing Orders and Dona Donations)

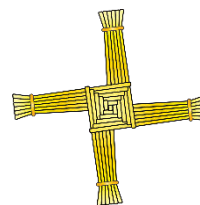
Weekly Collection 6th Sept: £7727.90

Monthly Collection 6th Sept: £4975.46

Mass Intentions for week ahead

Mon 14th Sept 7pm: *Special Intention*
 Tues 15th Sept 9.30am: *Bernard Downey (A)*
 Wed 16th Sept 9.30am: *Patricia Gilligan (A)*
 Fri 18th Sept 7pm: *Special Intention*
 Sat 19th Sept 12 Noon: *Malachy Owens (A)*
 Sat 19th Sept 6pm: *Samuel McShane (A)*

St Brigid's Parent and Toddler Group will start back on Thursday 17th September from 10.00am until 11.45am in St Brides Parish Hall.



Saint Brigid's Parish

24th Sunday in O T
 13th September 2026, Year A

Parish Priest: Fr Michael Sheehan **Tel:** 028 9066 5409

Parish Office: 028 9066 5409; (9 am - 1 pm Weekdays)

Address: 40 Derryvolgie Avenue, Belfast, BT9 6FP

Email: stbrigids@downandconnor.org **Website:** stbrigidsparishbelfast.org

Livestream/Webcam: youtube.com/@stbrigidsparishbelfast



24th Sunday in Ordinary Time

First Reading: Reading from the book of Ecclesiasticus Sir 27:30-28:7
Forgive your neighbour the hurt he does you, and when you pray, your sins will be forgiven

Responsorial Psalm: Ps 102:1-4.9-12
The Lord is compassion of love, slow to anger and rich in mercy.

Second Reading: Reading from the St Paul to the Romans Rm 14:7-9
Alive or dead we belong to the Lord.

Gospel: According to Matthew Mt 18:21:35
I do not tell you to forgive seven times, but seventy-seven times.

Anniversary List

Please pray for those whose anniversaries are at this time: Joseph Murtagh, Raymund Shearer, Patricia Gilligan, Malachy Owens, Desmond Shearer, Kathleen and Tom Kelly, Maureen Salters, Geraldine Donnelly, Kevin Mulholland, Mary Maguire, Brigid and John McKenna, Barney and Cis McCartan, Charlie Grant;

May they rest in peace

QUEEN'S CATHOLIC CHAPLAINCY – WE'RE BACK!

The Catholic Chaplaincy at Queen's reopens for the new academic year on **Monday 14 September**, with weekday Masses and our semester programme resuming. Our first Sunday Mass is 20 September at the new, earlier time of 7.00pm. Please note the new time!

ST BRIGID'S MORNING PRAYER

We are recommencing morning prayer at **7.30am on 14th September 2026 in the Side Chapel** and each subsequent Monday until the beginning of Advent during which we will meet each weekday morning until just before Christmas.

All parishioners and friends are warmly welcomed

The format follows the Morning Office includes a reading and reflection on the gospel and introduces the rhythm of the daily office and especially the psalms to our daily lives. Why not come along and experience for yourselves?

Women's Prayer Group

*Are you looking to find a closer relationship with God?
If so, St Brigid's Women's Prayer Group may be for you.*

We are a group of women of all ages who come together once a month. It's a very gentle hour in which we study a passage of scripture and pray. It's a community that continues to grow, developing relationship with not only God, but with one another too.

We meet the third Wednesday of each month, for about an hour, in the Parish Office at 7.30pm. We start with a cup of tea and a chat. There is always wisdom, support and good humour to be found amongst us. If you decide to join us you will receive the warmest of welcomes.

The next meetings are 16th September, 21st October, 18th November and 16th December.

Further info from Mary 07718263019

The Men's Morning Prayer group

Recommences on Friday 18th September at 7.30am in 40 Derryvolgie Avenue. This is an opportunity to reflect on the gospel for the following Sunday recite the morning office and build fraternity, as we seek to follow Christ in our daily lives.

CHAPLET OF DIVINE MERCY

We're back after our summer break!!

You are warmly invited by your local Lay Dominicans to join us as we pray the chaplet of Divine Mercy in St Brigid's church every FRIDAY at 3pm.

It's a beautiful way to start the weekend, so please join us.



? LIFE AFTER ALPHA ?

INVITATION TO CONTINUE THE JOURNEY ChristLife 'FOLLOWING CHRIST' course



FOLLOWING CHRIST is a 7-week course with a one day Retreat to help you grow as a disciple of Jesus. The course will commence on **TUESDAY 15 SEPTEMBER 2026 at 7:00pm in HOLY ROSARY PARISH CENTRE, 503 Ormeau Road, BT7 3GR.**

To register for 'FOLLOWING CHRIST' course, please send your full name, your e-mail address and mobile telephone number to stbrigids@downandconnor.org

St Brigid's One World Group

Annual Collection and Standing Order Appeal 2026

Please help people suffering from extreme poverty in developing countries whose needs are growing every year because of:

- the spiralling costs of food and other basic commodities
- devastating floods and droughts caused by climate change
- the impacts of war
- growing inequalities between rich and poor
- the significant reduction of aid from Governments.



Please contribute to our Annual Collection this weekend and/or consider making a regular donation by setting up a Standing Order online with your bank or by completing a Standing Order form.

If you are a UK taxpayer and Gift Aid your donations, we can claim a further 25% of the amount from HMRC.

Gift Aid envelopes and Standing Order forms are available at the back of the Church.

Donations may be made electronically or Standing Orders set up online

Account No 68825172 Sort Code 90-22-07

Envelopes can also be returned in the collection basket at any Mass over the coming weeks.

For information, email stbrigids1wg@gmail.com or phone Kevin on 07525634440

Confirmation Preparation Classes 2026/2027

Enrolment for St Brigid's Parish Confirmation Preparation Classes 2026/27 is now open to Year 7 pupils, who are not attending St Brigid's Primary School, and Year 8 pupils. Each class lasts one hour, 5.45pm-6.45pm, on Tuesdays in St. Brigid's Parish Hall. **The limited places available** will be awarded on the first come first served basis. Please contact the Parish Office stbrigids@downandconnor.org or 90665409 for further enrolment details.



Living Water
Season of Creation 2026

Immersion in Living Water
EZEKIEL 47:9, 12

Season of Creation 2026 (1 September – 4 October). Join us ...

The Season of Creation is the annual Christian celebration which invites us to respond in hope and commit to positive action meeting the challenge and responsibility to care for creation - our common home. As we journey through the Season of Creation from 1 September through to the feast-day of St Francis of Assisi on 4 October, let us each take one action to care for our planet, our common home.

What action will we take in this season to show care for our planet, our common home?

Action an Eco - tip

- Endeavour to buy locally sourced food on one shopping visit
- Make one journey on foot or use public transport
- Select one day and turn off all non- essential lights

Start the conversation with family and friends – what can we do to care for our common home? Involve young people in our conversations – their voice matters - they will inherit the planet that we create.

Read and consider what others are saying

Keep informed and join wider discussions by visiting info@jointhedotstogether.org
Read My Appeal (paragraphs 13 - 16) Laudato Si' - On Care for Our Common Home - visit www.vatican.va

Contribute your ideas and talents

Join our parish 'Care for Common Home' group to share ideas on eco-tips and suggestions for future talks/events — contact through the Parish Office.

Let's rise to the challenge

Pope Frances had every confidence that we can make change happen.
'All of us can cooperate as instruments of God for the care of creation, each according to his or her own culture, experience, involvements and talents' (LS14).

St Brigid's Care for Our Common Home Group

We are continuing our discussions around moving to solar panels - an action to reduce parish building carbon emissions.

St Brigid's Care for Our Common Home Group

Stretch. Breathe. Connect.

The Parish Community Association welcomes you back to our much-loved **Yoga sessions**—designed to refresh your body and lift your spirit.

- Starting:** Monday 14th September 2026
- Time:** 12:30 pm (*doors open at 12:15 pm – come early and settle in!*)
- Venue:** St Brigid's Parish Centre – Main Hall
- Open to:** All ages, all abilities – absolutely everyone is welcome!

Why you'll love it:

- **Expert guidance** – Learn poses safely and at your own pace
- **Just £5** – Quality wellness that won't break the bank
- **Friendly vibes** – A lovely way to meet new people in our community

Please bring your own yoga mat – you'll need it for the full session.

Come as you are. Leave feeling brighter.

Give it a go – your mind (and body) will thank you. We can't wait to see you there!

Set Dancing

The Parish Community Association welcomes you back to our weekly Set Dancing classes with Ronan Eastwood

Have fun, keep fit and get ready for the Fleadh next year!

- Starting:** Wednesday 16th September 2026
- Time:** 11:15am- 12:45pm (*doors open at 11:00am*)
- Venue:** St Brigid's Parish Centre – Downstairs Hall
- Open to:** All ages, all abilities – absolutely everyone is welcome!
- Only £5 per session**

Classes will run every week with a break on 28th October and a pre Christmas party on 16th December in the afternoon from 1:30pm - 3:30pm

Gaeilge agus Cultúr weekly in St Bride's Parish Hall

Tuesday 8th September, 2pm to 3pm. Irish for those with a little.

Thursday 10th September, 10am to 11am Irish for beginners.

Thursday 17th September, 1.30 to 3.30 amateur dramatics, no experience necessary.

Thursday 24th September 6.30 to 8.30 Gaeilge Choir, no fluency required.

Contact Máire for more information 07748482025/ amharcababu@hotmail.com



ST COLMCILLE'S CHURCH, HOLYWOOD PARISH

Fr Stephen P McBrearty PP

2A My Lady's Mile, Holywood, BT18 9EW Tel: 028 9042 2167 Office Hours: 10.00am – 2.00pmEmail: holywood@downandconnor.orgWebsite: www.stcolmcilleshollywood.org

Thinking about becoming Catholic, or want to deepen your understanding of the faith? The Diocesan RCIA

(Rite of Christian Initiation of Adults) is a journey of faith, formation and community for adults wishing to explore the teachings of Jesus Christ and the Catholic Church. It is open to anyone unbaptised, those baptised in another Christian tradition, or Catholics wishing to reconnect with their faith. **The 2026-2027 programme begins on Wednesday 23rd Sept** and runs weekly from 6.30pm to 8pm in St Mary's Hall Chapel Lane Belfast. Sessions include prayer, teaching, discussion and time for questions. Spouses, fiancés, and friends are also welcome to attend alongside participants. Further details are on our website.



Lay Bereavement Ministry – Volunteers Needed

Parishioners are invited to consider becoming **Lay Bereavement Ministers, a new ministry replacing Bethany Bereavement**. Ministers offer compassionate

support to those who are grieving through visits, telephone contact, group support and parish remembrance events. We are looking for people with good listening and communication skills, a caring and non-judgemental approach, reliability, and an active parish faith. A minimum team of 4 people is required, with ministry carried out in pairs. Teams can also work across a Family of Parishes. **Training: 29 September–14 November** at the Diocesan Offices, 120 Cliftonville Road, Belfast. Attendance at all six sessions is required. **Application deadline: 12 noon, Friday 18 September**. Places are limited. Further information is on our website www.stcolmcilleshollywood.org

PARISH OFFICE – REDUCED HOURS: Please note that the Parish Office will be operating at reduced hours from **Monday 14th September until Wednesday 23rd September**. If you would like to arrange a Mass to be offered for a family member or loved one, please contact the Parish Office by: Email: holywood@downandconnor.org Telephone: 028 9042 2167 — please leave a voicemail if we are unable to answer. We will respond to your request as soon as possible.

MASS TIMES

Saturday vigil Mass 6.30pm

Sunday 10am & 12noon

Weekday Mass

Monday at 7.00pm

Tuesday Wednesday &

Thursday at 9.30am

Friday at 7.00pm

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**Tuesday - St Anthony's Novena during the Mass.**  
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**Friday–Novena of Our Lady of Perpetual Succour during Mass.**  
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**Exposition of the Blessed Sacrament for 30 mins before each Mass**  
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Eucharistic Adoration

Every Saturday

12noon – 5.00pm

And before weekday Mass

For 30 Mins

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*Confession is by appointment only – Please contact the parish office for further details*  
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Church Opening Times For Private Prayer

Monday and Friday

Open all day for evening

Mass at 7pm

Tuesday, Wednesday &

Thursday open until 3pm

Saturdays 12noon to 5pm

and Sunday until 1pm.

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### REMEMBERING OUR DEPARTED

***We pray for those who have died recently and for those whose anniversaries occur around this time.***

**Recently Deceased** Peter McCoy, Margaret McConville, Frank McGrath, Brenda Brennan, Frank Boyd

**Months Mind:** May Rice (Dundalk)

**Anniversaries:** Maura Muldoon, Etta McGarry, James Dobbin, Carolyn Gibbons, Mary O'Doherty, Roseleen Largey, Byran Largey, David, Patrick and Elizabeth Dorrian, Cordelia Garvey, Desmond Herdman-Grant (40<sup>th</sup>) Freda Muckle, Ann Marie Rafferty (2<sup>nd</sup>), Frank Gray, V Rev Brendan F McGarry, Rev Tom Gartlan, V Rev Francis McKenna,



# 24<sup>th</sup> Sunday in Ordinary Time

## Sunday 13<sup>th</sup> September 2026



Look upon us, O God, Creator and ruler of all things,  
and, that we may feel the working of your mercy, grant that we may serve you with all  
our heart. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and reigns with you in the  
unity of the Holy Spirit, God, for ever and ever.



St Vincent de Paul Helpline Number:  
07845 854671

To donate directly to our bank

account, the details are as follows:

**Account Name: Ulster Bank Springhill**

**Account Number: 10523499**

**Sort Code: 98-07-60**

If you would prefer to phone directly to donate money, please phone 028 90750161 and mention Holywood. Thank you for your continued support during these difficult times. If you can, please remember to Gift Aid your donation

### DAY RETREAT TO LOUGH DERG

**Saturday 19th September**

Leaving St Paul's at 6.30am Returning to St Paul's at 7.30pm the day includes bus, boat, tea & scones on arrival then a light lunch and retreat. The theme of the retreat is "It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me"

(Galatians 2:20). The morning will include prayer, teaching, fellowship and men's testimonies, with Fr Eddie McGee as keynote speaker.

All men are very welcome. Price for Retreat is £45 plus the bus price determined on the uptake. Telephone St Paul's Parish Office on 028 90325034 Mon – Thurs to book a place.



### Defibrillator Training – Volunteers Needed

Our new defibrillator is located just inside the church entrance, beside the toilets. While it is simple to use without prior training, we are offering short training sessions in September to help parishioners feel confident using it in an emergency. We still need volunteers from all three weekend Masses to complete the training. No first aid experience is required. If you would like to take part, please contact the Parish Office with your usual Mass time and contact details thank you.



**St Colmcille's Ballyhackamore at 7.30pm**

Join us on the first and third Tuesday every month to recharge your spiritual batteries through prayer, study and friendship. First Tuesday – Adoration with Guided Meditation and Confession. Third Tuesday Group Study Course.

**SCRIPTURE GROUP:** We are delighted to announce that our **Scripture Group will be starting back on Monday 14th September at 7.30pm in Gartan**, directly after Evening Mass. Everyone is warmly welcome to come along, whether you have joined us before or are new to the group. It's a lovely opportunity to come together, reflect on Scripture and share in faith and fellowship. If you would like to join us, please contact **Paul Logan on 07798 655654.**

Church Cleaning Morning – **Monday 28<sup>th</sup> Sept at 10am.** If you can spare an hour, we'd love your help — many hands make light work!  
Thank you!

### DOWN AND CONNOR DIOCESAN TRUST ST MATTHEW'S PARISH, BELFAST VACANCY – PART-TIME HOUSEKEEPER

St Matthew's Parish, Bryson Street, Belfast, is seeking a part-time Housekeeper to provide a reliable cleaning service and assist with the preparation and serving of food and beverages for the Parish Priest. The successful applicant will help maintain a clean, welcoming parish house for the Parish Team, volunteers and visitors. Hours: 12 hours per week Contract: Permanent  
Rate of pay: £12.71 gross per hour  
Working pattern: To be agreed with the Parish Priest; some flexibility may be required.  
For full details, including the **Role Profile and Application Form**, visit the Diocesan website at [www.downandconnor.org](http://www.downandconnor.org) and select **Job Vacancies**, or visit Community NI. Application packs are also available from the Parish Office.  
**Closing date:** 12 noon, Monday 28th September 2026. Down and Connor Diocesan Trust is an Equal Opportunities Employer.

### Diocesan Vocations Summer Newsletter

Read our latest newsletter and join us in praying for vocations to priesthood, religious life and Christian service. [www.stcolmcilleshollywood.com](http://www.stcolmcilleshollywood.com)

### Could You Help Share the True Spirit of Christmas? Each

year, volunteers in parishes across the north of Ireland set up a small stall after Masses to sell **Trócaire's Gifts of Change** — meaningful gifts that make a real difference to families living in poverty around the world. **We provide everything you need** including training and support. All we ask is a little time and a big heart. Last Christmas, **50 parishes** took part — and we'd love to grow that number even more this year! If you would like to find out more about how you can help, please email Mark at [mark.mcmahon@trocaire.org](mailto:mark.mcmahon@trocaire.org) or call **028 9080 8030**.

### Diocesan Vocations Summer Newsletter

We are delighted to share with you the Diocese of Down and Connor Vocations Summer Newsletter. The newsletter offers an insight into the many ways in which vocations are being nurtured and encouraged across our Diocese, as well as the work taking place to support those discerning God's call. We invite parishioners to take some time to read and reflect on the newsletter and to continue to pray for vocations to the priesthood, religious life and all forms of Christian service. Copies of the Newsletter are on our website [www.stcolmcilleshollywood.com](http://www.stcolmcilleshollywood.com)

**Poetry & Presence** begins on Thursday 1 October at 7pm in the Belfast Jesuit Centre, opening with the theme of Water in this Season of Creation. You're invited into a quiet, reflective evening of poetry, art, music, and Scripture: a space to pause, breathe, and let the imagery of water in God's story speak to the depths of your own heart.

 Thursday 1 October  7.00pm  Belfast Jesuit Centre To register, visit

<https://belfastjesuitcentre.co.uk/poetry-presence/>

### Marriage Enrichment Weekend

**2nd to 4th October:** Marriage Encounter Ireland invites married couples to a residential Weekend from Friday 2nd to Sunday 4th October 2026 at the "Focolare Centre" "Curryhills", Prosperous, Co. Kildare. Step away from daily distractions to deepen your communication, renew your love, and rediscover the joy of your marriage.

[www.marriageencounter.ie](http://www.marriageencounter.ie)

### Beginning Experience – Bereavement Support

Beginning Experience is a peer ministry supporting those who are bereaved, separated or divorced. It is part of the Family Ministry of the Diocese of Down and Connor. The loss of a partner through death, separation or divorce can be devastating. Beginning Experience is offering a programme of bereavement support over three Saturdays:

 **Saturday 26th September**

 **Saturday 24th October**

 **Saturday 21st November**

 St Bride's Hall, Derryvolgie Avenue, Belfast

**Booking is essential.**

For further information or to book a place, please contact Marie on 07896 119669 or email

[belfastbe@yahoo.com](mailto:belfastbe@yahoo.com).

*You do not have to walk through loss alone*

**Beginning Experience:** The loss of a partner through death, separation or divorce is devastating. Beginning Experience is offering a programme of bereavement support in St Bride's Hall, Derryvolgie Ave., Belfast **Booking essential.** To find out more, contact

Pauline [07519289185](tel:07519289185) or Marie [07896119669](tel:07896119669) or email [belfastbe@yahoo.com](mailto:belfastbe@yahoo.com)

### Abide in His Love Women's Conference.

The Great Northern Hotel, Bundoran, **20–22 November 2026**. Join women from across Ireland for a faith-filled weekend with inspiring speakers including Sarah Swafford, Danielle Noonan, Fr Mark Wharton, Fr Barry Braum, Fr Oisín Martin, the Dominican Sisters of Nashville, Bishop Fintan Gavin, and more. A conference not to be missed!

Register now: <https://abideinhislove.eventbrite.com/>

### Community Set Dancing Classes in Holywood

are starting again on **Monday 14th Sep (7.30pm - 9.00pm)**. Great exercise and good fun. Very different to Riverdance. No need to come with a partner - just comfortable shoes and a friendly disposition! This is an adult class but children over the age of 14 are welcome but need to be accompanied by a parent or guardian. Each class costs £5 (£3 for those under 25). Please call Kevin Mac Mahon on 07940 803839 to reserve a place or for further information



### **The Chosen – Season 2 at the Belfast Jesuit Centre:** Weekly screenings of *The Chosen*:

Season 2 continues each Friday at the Belfast Jesuit Centre. Tea/coffee at 10.45am, episode at 11.00am, followed by a reflective Examen and discussion. All are welcome; no registration required.

Episode dates: 18 Sept, 25 Sept, 2 Oct, 9 Oct, 16 Oct, 23rd October.

Contact: [bjc@jesuit.ie](mailto:bjc@jesuit.ie) | 07955 282371 |

[belfastjesuitcentre.co.uk](http://belfastjesuitcentre.co.uk)



### **St Vincent de Paul – Treasurer**

**Could you help us?** We are

looking for a reliable and community-minded person to take on the role of Treasurer for our St Vincent de Paul Group. If you have bookkeeping experience or have previously held a similar position, we would love to hear from you. Your experience would be greatly appreciated and would be a valuable help to our group. If you think you might be interested, or would simply like to find out more, please leave your contact details with Claire in the Parish Office.



### **Stay Connected with Our Parish!**

Join the PPC Facebook Page! Want to stay up to date with parish news, events, announcements, photos, and

other important information? Follow and like our PPC Facebook page to keep connected with our parish community throughout the week.

👉 Find us on Facebook: St Colmcilles Parish  
Join us online. Stay connected. Be part of our parish community!



### **A Year of Ignatian Prayer**

**2026-2027**

**Belfast Jesuit Centre**

There are a few places remaining on our immersive programme in Ignatian Spirituality, which returns on Saturday 26<sup>th</sup> September; offering ten in-person Saturdays (10am–4pm) in the BJC and seven online Integrative Practice Pause Points to support prayer, discernment and reflective living. Open to those new to Ignatian Spirituality and those seeking to deepen their practice.

Suggested donation: £200–£280. Bursaries available. For dates and registration, please visit:

<https://belfastjesuitcentre.co.uk/a-year-of-ignatian-prayer-2026-2027/>

### **Requests for Masses for Deceased**

#### **Relatives and Friends**

#### **In remembrance of loved ones –**

To request a Mass for an Intention of a family member or friend. Please give your request either by calling the office 028 90422167

(Option 2) or by sending an email to

[holywood@downandconnor.org](mailto:holywood@downandconnor.org)

Although we cannot guarantee the date your request will be available,

Fr Stephen will be offering

a Mass for the Intention each day



**RADIO MARIA**  
IRELAND

Thank God and sincere thanks also to our many listeners and supporters as RADIO MARIA IRELAND continues to grow. As an Irish-run Catholic Talk-

Radio Station we enjoy commercial free broadcasting - Prayer, Catechesis, Uplifting music, Talks, Interviews and Testimonies – do join our growing faith family! Here's how you can listen:

Via Digital TV - Saorview Channel 210

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Via our 'Listen Live Radio' link on our Facebook Page. Why not drop a line to our Spiritual Director, Fr Des Farren by text on 089-4672000, by phone on

01-4123456, or come and pay us a visit at

Radio Maria Ireland, St. Anthony's Business Park, Ballymount Road, Dublin 22. D22 R7W2

# Sunday Message

TWENTY-FOURTH SUNDAY IN ORDINARY TIME

## THE WORD

Year A • 13 September 2026 • Colour: Green • Psalter Week 4

## TO FORGIVE WITHOUT LIMIT

MT 18:21-35



Peter asks Jesus how many times he should forgive someone. Jewish tradition said that God forgives three times and punishes on the fourth. Since human beings couldn't be more forgiving than God, forgiveness was, therefore, limited to three times.

Peter must have thought that forgiving someone seven times was more than generous, since it went far beyond what Jewish tradition taught. But Jesus says it's not enough; the Christian must forgive seventy times seven—in other words, never stop forgiving.

Jesus always showed mercy. As Pope Francis put it, the only people Jesus condemns are those who think they don't need it. "Jesus does not say, 'Blessed are those who plot revenge,' Pope Francis said. "He calls 'blessed' those who forgive and do so 'seventy times seven.' All of us have been looked upon with divine compassion. If we approach the Lord with sincerity and listen carefully, there may well be times when we hear his reproach: 'Should not you have had mercy on your fellow servant, as I had mercy on you?'"

In other words, we must forgive because God has forgiven us. We must never stop forgiving. ■

## DO

Is there somebody you need to forgive or with whom you need to be reconciled? Perhaps you could seek them out this week.

## SAY

"The Lord is compassion and love."

## PRAY

For the Christian, there can be no limit to mercy and forgiveness. Pray for the strength to forgive always.

## LEARN

Mercy was at the heart of Jesus' ministry

Forgiveness sets us free

We must think of ourselves as an army of the forgiven

## REFLECT

What can we Christians say about forgiveness?

1. People are basically good. We have an innate goodness. The creation story in Genesis tells us God saw all that God had made and found it very good. In *Laudato Si*, Pope Francis uses a beautiful word to describe God's relationship with creation: All is a caress of God. When we see people as good, then we will treat them differently.
2. God forgives us first. That's the story of salvation. No matter how often God's people strayed, God never gave up on them. As Pope Francis puts it in his memoir *Hope*, we children get up to all kinds of things, we make mistakes, we sin, but when we ask for pardon, God's mercy embraces us and forgives us, always. God never tires of embracing and forgiving us. It is we who sometimes grow tired of asking for pardon. God never tires of forgiving us.
3. In receiving forgiveness, we give the past over to God - and let it go. We all know people who find this hard to do. They keep revisiting past sins. Crucified by scruples, they worry they didn't confess properly last time or didn't include everything. The

scrupulous aren't free. They've been so badly damaged by some event that they've been stuck ever since. Forgiveness sets us free, but not if we can't let go of the past. The challenge is to give the past over to God and live the present in love.

4. In order to live the present in love, we must be able to forgive ourselves. We can find that hard to do, especially if there's something in our past we feel especially guilty about. If I can't forgive myself, it's going to be hard to forgive others. If God can forgive me, then I must forgive myself.
5. Pope Francis described forgiveness as "a human right. The ability to be forgiven is a human right. We all have the right to be forgiven." In his letter on marriage and the family, *Amoris laetitia* (The Joy of Love), he says that pastors must "avoid judgements which do not take into account the complexity of various situations" and must "be attentive to how people experience distress because of their condition." All of us have been looked upon with divine compassion," he writes. "We should hear God saying to us, 'Should not you have had mercy on your fellow servant, as I had mercy on you?'"

Being compassionate, he continues, doesn't mean watering down church

teaching. Jesus proposed a demanding ideal, but "never failed to show compassion and closeness to the frailty of individuals like the Samaritan woman or the woman caught in adultery."

6. Conversion is always a work in progress. Pope Francis had a word for it: gradualism. In *Amoris laetitia*, he says that no one drops down from heaven perfectly formed; "families need constantly to grow and mature in the ability to love... All of us are called to keep striving towards something greater than ourselves and our families, and every family must feel this constant impulse."

My true self is something I must keep striving toward, turning from my old life to one like Christ's. My conversion is ongoing. I must work at being a better me, seeking to love more, forgive more, be kinder, more compassionate, more tolerant. I'll never be perfect, but I must keep trying. That's gradualism.

7. Forgiveness sets us free. To forgive is to stop wasting energy on resentment and grudges. In forgiving, I liberate myself to live. As Lewis Smedes put it in *Forgive and Forget*, "To forgive is to set a prisoner free and to discover that the prisoner was you." ■